

We are living through a moment where the plate is louder than the palate—where food must announce itself before it can be understood, and where the performance of eating often eclipses the act itself. The question is not whether flavour has diminished, but whether we have stopped paying attention to it in the same way.



The anxiety that flavour is taking a back seat isn't entirely misplaced—but it's also not the whole story. What we're witnessing is a shift in how food is consumed, not just how it is cooked. Dining today is no longer a private act between plate and palate; it is a public performance. The first bite is often taken by the camera. And so, the plate has been asked to do something new: to arrest attention before it earns affection.

In that context, visual drama, conceptual storytelling, and what people dismiss as "gimmickry" have become a language. But languages evolve because something deeper is changing. We are living in a moment where memory is externalised—documented, shared, validated. A dish is no longer just nourishment or even pleasure; it is content, identity, currency.

And yet, this isn't unprecedented. Every era of cooking has flirted with excess. Classical French cuisine elevated precision to the point of intimidation. The era of molecular gastronomy gave us foams, spheres, and a radical rethinking of technique. It was thrilling, transformative—and ultimately unsustainable in its purest form.

The legendary American critic Gail Greene once cut through that moment with brutal clarity, calling this strain of cooking "brain effing with no orgasm." It was said half in jest, but with full intent. Because what she was pointing to was not technique, but absence—the loss of pleasure, of satisfaction, of that deeply human response to food that cannot be intellectualised or staged.

And that absence is something diners are quietly beginning to feel. Across India and globally, people are spending thousands on meals that are hyper-tweaked, hyper-tweezered, hyper-styled to reflect locality, seasonality, philosophy, narrative—everything except, sometimes, memory. They admire, they photograph, they discuss. But the next day, many cannot recall what they actually ate. The meal lingers as an idea, not as a craving.

And so, almost instinctively, they return home and order what they remember with their bodies: butter chicken, dal makhani, a simple khichdi, a familiar bowl of something that does not need explanation. This is not regression—it is a correction. Because while the mind may be seduced by performance, the body continues to seek satiety, comfort, and pleasure.

When that balance is lost, it does a quiet disservice—not just to Indian cuisine, but to food everywhere. Because the consequence is not that people become more adventurous; it is that they oscillate. They experience the high-concept meal, and then they retreat to the most accessible version of satisfaction—sometimes even to the lowest common denominator. It is why, after nights of elaborate tasting menus, people still find themselves